

The tank in peace and war

Like all weapons, the tank can be viewed in many different ways. All too often it is seen as a symbol of oppression, invasion, and menace—for many, however, precisely the opposite is true. Here, for example, on the ruined streets of Flers, Normandy, soon after the D-Day landings of June 1944, the tank is a bringer of liberation; the flags are out and the population is welcoming the troops.

Such differing views of the tank were already clear in World War I, almost as soon as the tank was invented. On the British home front, toys, teapots, a handbag, all kinds of souvenirs and even a dance paid homage to the vehicle that had turned the tide on Germany. At last, Britain was ahead of the country

that had been the first to use airpower when it bombed London and the first to use poison gas on the battlefield. Subsequently, the tank became a huge success in raising money for the war effort and many were sent on tour around Britain. For the Germans, on the other hand, by late 1918 the appearance of a tank on the battlefield simply gave exhausted and demoralized soldiers an excuse to surrender. As Hindenburg said: “that they could cross our undamaged trenches and obstacles did not fail to have a marked effect on our troops.”

A British-crewed Sherman tank makes its way through the ruins of Flers, Normandy, in 1944. A bulldozer clears rubble in the background.

